of the academy. Having reached the cadets' living area, we got down from the buses, identified our baggage and put name tags on them. We were told that our boxes would be sent to our rooms (called 'cabins' – a naval term), but a warm reception awaited us on the way. That was our first experience of ragging. We were expecting it, because everyone who knew about the NDA had warned us about it, but what we experienced was unbelievable. At times, it was cruel, sadistic and almost inhuman! We measured the distance to the cadets' mess not by walking but by 'front-rolling', a term denoting a human ball rolling on the tarmac. We soon learnt how to fold our torso in a round configuration, perhaps a shade better than when we were in our mother's womb. It did not take us time to realize that while riding our cycles we exposed ourselves to being saddled with a 'golden necklace'. That meant continuing our journey carrying the cycle around our necks in case we failed to pay compliments to our seniors, were out of line or simply because we crossed the path of a mean son-of-a-bitch. The worst part of it was that the senior cadet who awarded the punishment generally vanished, without giving any orders about the termination of the punishment. For all it mattered, a sincere and disciplined first-termer could be on his haunches leaping like a frog, front-rolling or running around an 'imaginary tree' the whole night.

It wasn't difficult to spot a first-termer as we were in civilian clothes till our uniforms and 'mufti' outfits were tailored and issued to us. Besides, our body language gave us away even when we had received our uniforms, later in the term. There appeared to be a stamp somewhere on our person which nailed us. The whole issue of ragging seemed bizarre and silly. In our squadron, we had a daily dose of ragging after dinner; the physical aches and pain made it difficult for us to laugh it off, and it was pointless crying. There was no one to comfort us. It was like the 'death lane' in the equestrian training area, where the rider and the horse were put in a barricaded enclosure with a series of jumps which the horse was trained to clear with or without the rider in the saddle. The latter eventuality was a frequent occurrence. So we learnt to get on with life by ourselves – graduating into manhood.